

Connecting Claude Code to Browsers

A concise technical guide to integrating official Anthropic extensions, human-agent browsers, and MCP runners directly with the CLI.

Plan Notice: Official Chrome Extension vs. API Key Billing

The official **Claude in Chrome** extension operates strictly with paid Anthropic subscription plans (**Claude Pro, Claude Max, Team, or Enterprise**). It does **not** work on standalone pay-as-you-go API key billing. If you are using API billing, connect via the **Playwright**, **Puppeteer**, or **Browserbase** MCP servers instead.

CORE SETUP WORKFLOWS

QUICK START

WORKFLOW A (OFFICIAL)

Claude in Chrome

Install extension, sign in with your Pro/Max account, and start Claude Code using `claude --chrome`.

WORKFLOW B (SPACES)

ego (lite) Browser

Run `npx skills add citrolabs/ego-lite` to automate background tabs without mouse hijacking.

WORKFLOW C (UNIVERSAL)

Playwright / MCP

Run `claude mcp add ...` for headless DOM accessibility tree inspection under API or subscription.

PRIMARY BROWSER HARNESSES (1 / 2)

CORE OPTIONS

Claude in Chrome (Official)

Pro / Max Required

Anthropic's native extension via Native Messaging. Directly controls Chrome tabs with your active logins. Requires Claude Pro/Max/Team subscription.

```
# 1. Install extension from Chrome Web Store # 2. Launch
CLI with Chrome bridge active: $ claude --chrome # Or run
inside an active session: /chrome
```

ego (lite) Browser

Agent Coexistence

Chromium browser with dedicated background "Spaces". Shares your Chrome cookies, bookmarks, and sessions without stealing mouse focus.

```
$ npx skills add citrolabs/ego-lite # Inside session: /ego-
browser <instruction>
```

Playwright MCP

Universal Headless

Clean-room headless or headful runner. Provides structured accessibility trees, assertions, clicks, and page screenshots. Works with all billing models.

```
$ claude mcp add playwright \ -- npx -y
@playwright/mcp@latest
```

Puppeteer MCP

Official Reference

Reference server from the ModelContextProtocol repository. Lightweight Chromium instance ideal for console inspection and quick DOM queries.

```
$ claude mcp add puppeteer \ -- npx -y
@modelcontextprotocol/server-puppeteer
```

STATUS & HEALTH VERIFICATION

CLI DIAGNOSTICS

```
# Verify MCP-registered runners $ claude mcp list Checking servers... ✓ playwright: Connected (navigate, click, fill, screenshot, hover) ✓
puppeteer: Connected (puppeteer_navigate, puppeteer_screenshot) # For official Chrome extension: run inside session: > /chrome
```

Browserbase / Stagehand

Cloud Fleet

Offloads browser execution to hosted cloud infrastructure. Solves anti-bot captchas, handles stealth mode, and prevents local RAM exhaustion.

```
$ claude mcp add browserbase \ --env BROWSERBASE_API_KEY="bb_live_xxx" \ -- npx -y @browserbasehq/mcp-server-browserbase
```

BrowserMCP (Community)

Extension Bridge

Third-party extension-to-MCP bridge for Chrome. Grants Claude access to active tabs when using standard API key configurations.

```
$ claude mcp add browsermcp \ -- npx -y @browsermcp/mcp
```

BROWSER HARNESS COMPARISON MATRIX

DECISION FRAMEWORK

Harness / Runner	Plan / Account Requirement	Session & Auth State	Best Use Case
Claude in Chrome (Official)	Claude Pro, Max, Team, Enterprise (Not supported on API keys)	Direct access to current active Chrome tab & logins	Interactive web work, internal consoles, and tab co-working.
ego (lite)	Any (Skill-based agent runner)	Shares everyday Chrome cookies in background Spaces	Daily development without cursor stealing or active window disruption.
Playwright MCP	Any (API key or Subscription)	Isolated, ephemeral context per execution run	Local web UI testing, responsive layout checks, and E2E verification.
Puppeteer MCP	Any (API key or Subscription)	Transient Chromium process	Fast DOM scraping, console error tracking, and snapshot diffs.
Browserbase MCP	Browserbase API key (Any Claude setup)	Managed cloud sessions with proxy/stealth support	Automated CI/CD pipelines, heavy crawling, and captcha evasion.
Fetch MCP	Any (Lightweight HTTP client)	Header / Bearer tokens only (No DOM)	Reading static documentation, markdown, and public API endpoints.

PRODUCTION PROMPT PATTERNS

TERMINAL WORKFLOWS

```
# Pattern 1: Debugging local dev server with Playwright MCP > "Open http://localhost:3000, trigger responsive mobile view (390px), navigate to /checkout, and report any console error messages or hydration mismatches." # Pattern 2: Operating authenticated SaaS tabs via Claude in Chrome > "Look at my open Google Cloud Console tab, find the current Cloud Run service metrics for 'api-prod', and extract the container restart count over the last 24h." # Pattern 3: Parallel background workflow with ego (lite) > "/ego-browser Open GitHub pull requests assigned to me across the repo, check which ones failed CI, and summarize the error logs."
```

Architectural Summary • @thehustlerdev
If you pay for **Claude Pro** or **Claude Max**, utilize `claude --chrome` for instant zero-config tab co-working. If running on **API pay-as-you-go keys**, use **Playwright MCP** for clean test suites or **ego (lite)** for parallel authenticated tasks.